CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 01

WEEK OF 9 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



FINANCIAL SERVICES AND INSURANCE

Within tolerance.

A crisis playbook for banks, insurers, payment and investment firms. What to do in the first hour of a severe disruption, how to communicate when email and chat are down, and how to prove you can stay within your impact tolerances.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

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A practical crisis playbook for banks, insurers, payment and investment firms: how to keep important business services within tolerance on the worst day, run the first hour, talk to customers and regulators when normal channels fail, and gather the evidence a board and a supervisor will ask for.

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FOREWORD

Resilience on paper met a real morning on 20 October 2026.

At 06:53 BST on Tuesday 20 October 2026, the utility feed to a data centre hosting europe-west2-b, one of Google Cloud's London zones, failed. A second feed was switched out for repairs, and a control system fault stopped the backup generators from starting. When the batteries ran out at 07:00, servers in the zone lost power. Google's incident report puts the main impact across the London region at six hours and eight minutes.[1]

Customers of Lloyds, HSBC and Revolut reported problems with apps, payments and cash withdrawals that morning.[2,3] The FCA said it was engaging with Google, and the Treasury Committee wrote to the Bank of England and the FCA for details.[2] Google Cloud had been designated a critical third party to the UK financial sector just fourteen weeks earlier.[4]

Since 31 March 2025, UK banks, insurers, payment firms and many investment firms have been expected to show they can remain within impact tolerances for each important business service.[5] This playbook is about the practical side of that duty: the first hour, the messages, the suppliers and the evidence. Our companion intelligence report sets out the regulation and the record in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three questions decide how your worst day goes.

Regulators do not expect firms to prevent every disruption. They expect firms to know which services matter most, how much disruption customers and markets can bear, and how they will stay inside that limit when something fails.

Do we know what matters?

Important business services named, impact tolerances set and approved by the board, and every service mapped to the people, systems and suppliers it relies on.

Can we act in minutes?

A severity ladder everyone uses, a first-hour plan with named owners, and a way to reach the response team that does not depend on the systems that have failed.

Can we prove it?

Severe but plausible scenarios tested, communications included, and the timings, decisions and lessons recorded so the self-assessment stands up to challenge.

Resilience is measured on the customer's clock, not the supplier's.

A cloud provider can restore its service on its own timetable. Your impact tolerance keeps running from the moment your customers cannot pay, be paid or claim.

PART 01

Know your limits.

Before a crisis, decide which services matter most and how much disruption is too much.

01 Services, tolerances and mapping

02 Important business services by firm type

03 A severity ladder for financial services

KNOW YOUR LIMITS

Important business services and impact tolerances, in plain terms

> **A tolerance is the point at which harm becomes intolerable. Recovery targets should sit well inside it.**

The UK operational resilience rules, set out by the FCA in PS21/3 and by the PRA in SS1/21, ask a firm to look at itself from the outside in. An important business service is one that, if disrupted, could cause intolerable harm to customers or risk to market integrity, or for the PRA threaten the firm's safety and soundness or financial stability.[5,6]

For each one, the firm sets an impact tolerance: the maximum tolerable level of disruption. The PRA requires every tolerance to include a time metric, says it applies at peak times as well as normal ones, and expects firms to stay within it in severe but plausible scenarios, whether or not a third party delivers part of the service.[6]

The deadline mattered. Rules came into force on 31 March 2022, and by 31 March 2025 firms had to have done the mapping and testing to remain within tolerance, and made the investments to operate consistently within it.[5]

In March 2026, reviewing annual self-assessments, the FCA saw progress: clearer methods, annual reviews and some non-time metrics such as transaction volumes. It also found firms not setting distinct tolerances for consumer harm and market integrity, and mapping that focused mainly on technology.[7]

A tolerance is not a recovery time objective. It is the point at which harm becomes intolerable, so recovery targets usually sit well inside it. If your recovery plan only just fits within the tolerance, the plan is the risk.

The practical test is simple. Pick any important business service and ask three people to name its tolerance, its top three dependencies and who declares an incident. If the answers differ, start there.

ILLUSTRATIVE SERVICES

What an important business service looks like

Examples only. Each firm must identify its own services and justify its own tolerances.

FIRM TYPE	EXAMPLE SERVICE	TOLERANCE METRICS TO CONSIDER	HIDDEN DEPENDENCY
Retail bank	Making a payment from a current account	Hours of disruption at peak, number of customers and value of payments affected	Card processor, cloud region, fraud engine
Insurer	Making and paying a motor or home claim	Days to first contact and payment, with extra weight in a storm or flood	Claims platform supplier, contact centre telephony
Payments and e-money	Card authorisation and access to funds	Minutes of failed authorisations, share of transactions declined	Scheme connection, issuer processor, single hosting zone
Investment firm	Placing and settling client orders	Orders missed or delayed in market hours, settlement fails	Order management SaaS, market data, custodian links
Building society	Mortgage completion on the agreed day	Completions missed, with tolerance tightest at month end	Payment scheme access, conveyancer portal

SEVERITY

A severity ladder for financial services

Agree the triggers in advance so nobody debates the level while customers wait. If in doubt, declare higher and step down.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

An important business service is down or badly degraded and its impact tolerance is at risk. Customers cannot pay, be paid, reach cash or make a claim. Data integrity in doubt, or a suspected cyber attack on core systems.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Crisis team, executive on call, regulatory lead and communications lead. Board chair informed.

`Push, SMS, voice call · escalate after 5 minutes`

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

An important business service is degraded but a tested workaround is holding. One channel is down, such as the app but not cards. A material supplier declares an incident.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Incident team, service owners, supplier manager. Communications lead on standby.

`Push and SMS · bridge opened`

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

Internal system failure with little or no customer impact. Failover worked as designed. Elevated error rates under investigation.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Technology on call and the service owner.

`Push and email`

SEV 4

Watch

TRIGGERS

Supplier advisory, risky change window, severe weather warning or a peak day such as payday or month end ahead.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager logs it and briefs the next shift.

`Email and incident log`

PART 02

The first hour.

What happens in the first sixty minutes decides whether you stay within tolerance.

01 A T+ timeline for a cloud outage

02 When email and chat are down too

03 Messages for customers, staff and regulators

FIRST HOUR

Cloud outage at 07:00

A bank or payment firm whose app and cards depend on one cloud region. Owners are roles.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Alarms and complaints arrive together** Monitoring shows failed card authorisations and app logins as the contact centre and social channels light up.	DUTY INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:05	**Declare and page out of band** Declare SEV1 provisionally. Page the team by SMS and voice, not email or chat, which may share the failed dependency.	DUTY INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**Open the bridge, start the clock** Assign leads and a scribe. Record which important business services are hit, and when.	INCIDENT LEAD
T+00:15	**Call the provider, do not wait for it** Raise a priority case. On 20 October the first public update came about two and a half hours after impact began.[1]	SUPPLIER LEAD
T+00:30	**First word to customers** Holding message on the website, app and social channels. Contact centre script live. Flag customers who need urgent help.	COMMUNICATIONS LEAD
T+00:45	**Decide on failover** Invoke the tested move to another zone or region, or manual workarounds. Protect data integrity above speed.	TECHNOLOGY LEAD
T+01:00	**Tell the supervisor** Early call to FCA and PRA supervisors. Payment firms must report a major incident within 4 hours of detecting it.[8]	REGULATORY LEAD

OUT OF BAND

When email and chat go down with everything else

> **Out-of-band means a route that shares no critical dependency with the systems that have failed.**

The FCA's March 2026 review found firms often had not considered in detail the alternatives or workarounds when their usual communication channels are unavailable, and little evidence that communications strategies are tested in scenario exercises.[7]

In a cloud or identity outage, the tools a firm uses to coordinate may be the first casualties. If email, chat, the intranet and the incident ticketing system all sign in through the same identity provider or sit in the same cloud region, the response team cannot reach each other at the moment they most need to.

Out-of-band means a route that shares no critical dependency with the systems that have failed. In practice that is a combination: a mass notification service hosted separately from your estate, SMS and voice to personal and work mobiles, a fixed conference bridge with numbers printed in the plan, and an offline copy of contact lists and runbooks.

Test it the way it would fail. Run an exercise in which email and chat are declared unavailable for the first two hours. Measure how long it takes to reach the full response team, how many acknowledge, and who you could not reach at all.

The same thinking applies to customers. If the app is the channel that is down, the app banner cannot carry the message. Agree in advance which channels carry customer updates when the main one fails: the website status page, social accounts, SMS, branch staff, and the contact centre's recorded message.

Finally, keep the regulator's contact details outside your normal systems. A supervisor's mobile number in a locked mailbox helps nobody.

TEMPLATES

Six messages ready to send

Fill the brackets with confirmed facts only. Agree sign-off rules in advance so messages are not held up.

SMS · RESPONSE TEAM

142 chars

> SEV1 declared 07:05. Cards and app down. Join bridge now: [number] PIN [pin]. Do not use email or Teams. Reply 1 to confirm, 2 if unavailable.

No reply in 5 minutes: call the deputy.

SMS · BRANCH AND CONTACT CENTRE

132 chars

> Cards and app disrupted. Use script v3. Don't speculate on cause. Log customers who need urgent cash or payments. Next brief [time].

APP BANNER AND WEB · CUSTOMERS

> Some customers can't use our app or cards right now. We're working to fix this and will update you here by [time]. Sorry for the disruption.

Say money is safe only once confirmed.

EMAIL · CRITICAL SUPPLIER

> SEV1 affecting [service] since [time]. Within 15 minutes please confirm scope, your reference, a named engineer, an ETA and any workaround.

Copy the contract owner.

EMAIL AND PHONE · FCA AND PRA SUPERVISORS

> Since [time] an operational incident has affected [service]. Likely cause: third-party cloud disruption. Customers affected: about [n]. Tolerance [x] hours, [y] elapsed. Next update [time]. Contact: [name, mobile].

Formal reports follow the rules that apply.

STATEMENT · MEDIA HOLDING LINE

> We're aware some customers are having difficulty using our app and cards. We're working to restore services as quickly as possible and will update our website. We apologise to those affected.

No supplier or cause until confirmed.

CUSTOMERS AND REGULATORS

Telling customers and regulators: what good looks like

Most criticism after an outage is about silence and confusion, not the fault itself.

MOMENT	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
First 30 minutes	Silence while engineers diagnose the problem.	A holding message on every channel you still control, within 30 minutes.
Supervisors	First call made only once the cause is known.	An early heads-up, then formal reports to the clock. From 18 March 2027 most firms report within 24 hours of determining that a threshold is met.[8]
Vulnerable customers	One generic message for everyone.	Priority help for those who cannot reach cash, pay rent or complete a purchase that day.
Cause	Early speculation, or blaming a supplier.	Say what you know and what customers should do. Name the cause only when confirmed.
Updates	Irregular, and only when there is news.	A fixed cadence, such as every 60 minutes, even when nothing has changed.
Afterwards	Close quietly and move on.	Explain what happened, put right any financial loss and share the lessons.

PART 03

Prove it.

Map what you depend on, test the severe days and keep the evidence a board can rely on.

01 Where concentration hides

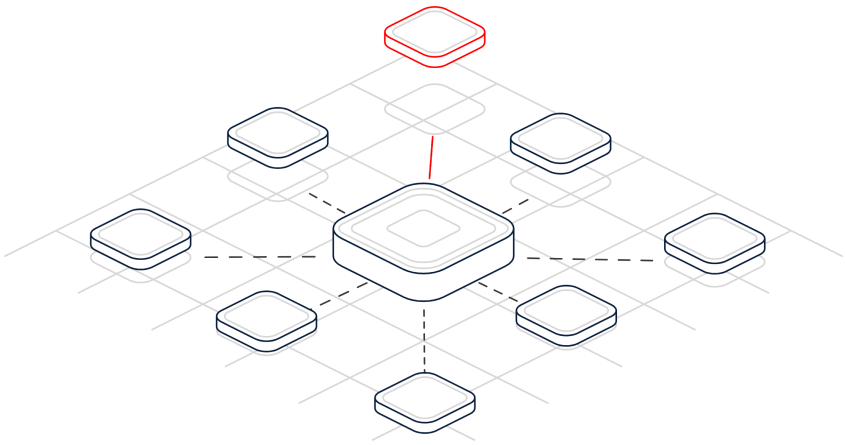
02 Three scenarios to test

03 Evidence and your 90-day plan

CONCENTRATION

Four places concentration hides

The UK designated four cloud providers as critical third parties in July 2026. Regulated firms remain responsible for managing their own third-party arrangements.[4,9]



01 One region, one zone

Services described as resilient may still run in a single zone, or rely on regional control systems that a zone failure can disrupt.

02 Shared tooling

Email, chat, identity and incident tooling often sit with the same provider as production. One outage removes both the service and the means to coordinate.

03 Your suppliers' suppliers

A claims platform or core banking SaaS may run in the same cloud region you chose to avoid.

04 Payments chains and people

Processors, scheme connections and fraud engines need tested alternatives. So do key teams working from a single site.

SCENARIOS

Three severe days to rehearse

RETAIL BANK

A cloud zone fails at 07:00 on payday

THE DISRUPTION

App, card payments and online transfers degrade across the region, not just the failed zone.

THE FIRST HOUR

SEV1 by SMS and voice, bridge open, customer holding message by T+00:30, supervisor called by T+01:00.

THE TEST

Fail over to another region in a live-like environment and time it against the tolerance.

WATCH OUT

Corporate email and chat run in the same region. Run the exercise without them.

PAYMENTS AND E-MONEY FIRM

Card processor outage on Black Friday

THE DISRUPTION

Authorisations fail for 40 minutes at peak, leaving customers stuck at tills.

THE FIRST HOUR

Switch to the standby route, push in-app guidance, report within 4 hours.

THE TEST

Prove the standby route carries peak volume, not just a test transaction.

WATCH OUT

Fraud rules may block legitimate payments once traffic moves.

GENERAL INSURER

Claims supplier hit by ransomware during a storm

THE DISRUPTION

The claims platform is offline as storm claims peak.

THE FIRST HOUR

Manual intake script, longer contact centre hours, brokers and supervisor told.

THE TEST

Run a week of claims by hand in a tabletop and count what breaks.

WATCH OUT

A data breach brings separate notification duties.

TESTING AND EVIDENCE

Test the severe days, then write it down

What the FCA's review of 2025 self-assessments rewards, turned into six steps.

01 Choose scenarios that could break you

Vary the nature, severity and duration. The FCA questions self-assessments that claim no scenario could defeat the firm without severe testing to show it.[7]

02 Include communications in every test

Declare email and chat unavailable. Time how long it takes to reach the team, the customer channels and the supervisor.

03 Run the tolerance clock

Record the start, each decision and the point of recovery against the tolerance for every affected service.

04 Plan for a breach

Where a scenario would breach a tolerance, document the longer-term remediation plan, with owners and dates.[7]

05 Make the self-assessment decision-ready

Add confidence ratings, second and third line input, and a clear ask of the board, which must review and approve it.[6,7]

06 Learn from real incidents

Use 20 October as a case study. Map which of your services would have been hit, and how you would have known.

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Check that the response team can be reached without corporate email or chat. Print the bridge number and supervisor contacts into the plan.	Head of resilience
This week	List every important business service that depends on a single cloud region or zone, including through suppliers.	CIO or CTO
This month	Agree the severity ladder and first-hour roles. Load the six message templates and their sign-off rules.	Head of resilience, communications lead
This month	Ask material suppliers how they notify you, how fast, and where their own dependencies sit.	Third-party risk lead
This quarter	Run a severe scenario with communications channels unavailable. Time it against tolerance and record the evidence.	Head of resilience
This quarter	Map incident reporting to the FCA and PRA rules that apply from 18 March 2027, and to DORA for EU entities.	Chief risk officer, compliance

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your executive committee

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

READINESS

- ? If our cloud region failed at 07:00 tomorrow, which important business services would breach tolerance first?
- ? Could we reach the whole response team in ten minutes without email or chat?
- ? Who is authorised to send the first customer message, and how fast?

EVIDENCE

- ? Which scenario in our last test came closest to breaching a tolerance, and what are we doing about it?
- ? Did our last test include communications, suppliers and the supervisor call?
- ? Would our self-assessment convince a sceptical board member?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready to stay within tolerance?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Important business services and tolerances approved by the board**
  Reviewed in the last twelve months or after material change.

- [ ] **Every service mapped to people, systems and suppliers**
  Including the cloud region and zone, and key fourth parties.

- [ ] **Severity ladder agreed and out-of-band alerting tested**
  The team reachable without corporate email, chat or single sign-on.

- [ ] **Message templates loaded**
  For customers, staff, supervisors, suppliers and the media, with sign-off rules.

- [ ] **Regulatory reporting clocks known**
  Current rules, PSP four-hour reports, the 2027 regime and DORA where relevant.

- [ ] **Severe scenario tested this year**
  With communications included and timings recorded against tolerance.

- [ ] **Self-assessment evidence ready**
  Confidence ratings, remediation owners and second line challenge.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Important business service
A service provided to an external user which, if disrupted, could cause intolerable harm or risk to the firm or the wider system.

Impact tolerance
The maximum tolerable level of disruption to an important business service, always including a time metric.

Mapping
Identifying the people, processes, technology, facilities and information that support each important business service.

Severe but plausible scenario
A demanding but realistic disruption used to test whether a firm can stay within tolerance.

Self-assessment
The written record of a firm's compliance with the resilience rules, reviewed and approved by the board.

Critical third party
A provider designated by HM Treasury whose services, if disrupted, could threaten UK financial stability or confidence.

Availability zone
An isolated location within a cloud region, with its own power and networking.

Out-of-band
A communication route that does not rely on the systems affected by the incident.

DORA
The EU Digital Operational Resilience Act, applying to EU financial entities from 17 January 2025.

Material third party arrangement
A supplier arrangement whose disruption could seriously affect a firm, which must be notified and registered under the 2027 regime.

PLATFORM

Where Crises Control fits

Seven steps in this playbook, and the modules that support them. Crises Control supports your plan; it does not replace it.

Page the response team by SMS, voice and push when email and chat are down, and escalate to deputies when nobody acknowledges.	**Ping** Mass alerting by push, SMS, voice and email, with acknowledgement tracking and escalation on no response.
Run one workspace per incident, with the bridge, decision log and approved message templates in one place.	**Incident Manager** A workspace per incident: team coordination, a single communication log and message templates.
Turn failover and manual workaround runbooks into tasks with owners, deadlines and escalation.	**Task Manager** Digitised procedures: tasks assigned with owners, deadlines and escalation paths.
Watch tasks, communications and escalations live against the tolerance clock for each affected service.	**Control Centre** A live view of tasks, communications, locations and escalations.
Keep timestamped timelines as evidence for supervisors, the post-incident review and the self-assessment.	**Audit Trail** Automatic timestamps and incident timelines, ready for the post-incident report.
Let branch and frontline staff raise an urgent issue with their location in one touch.	**SOS** One-touch mobile escalation with GPS location for frontline staff.
Draft role-specific updates for customers, staff and supervisors, then review before sending.	**CRAiG** AI assistant (beta) that drafts role-specific messages, translates and summarises.

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Sources were accessed in November 2026. Scenarios, templates and timings in this playbook are illustrative and should be adapted to your firm.

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Stay within tolerance on the worst day.

Crises Control helps banks, insurers, payment and investment firms reach the right people in minutes, run the response from one place and keep the evidence supervisors ask for.

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